

↘ THE VILLAGE [AMAZON PRIME VIDEO]

Based on a graphic novel, the Tamil series follows a family on a road trip that finds itself attacked by a clan of mutants. Arya of *Sarpatta Parambarai* fame headlines the cast.

↘ DHOOTHA [AMAZON PRIME VIDEO]

A Telugu supernatural horror in which 'possessed inanimate objects' wreak havoc on the lives of those who have sinned. Featuring Naga Chaitanya, Parvathy Thiruvothu and Prachi Desai.





↘ MEME BOYS [SONYLIV]

Four collegians run an anonymous meme page that takes on their oppressive college administration in this Tamil series.

writing", a whole new beast compared to writing for television and film with a required length of 250-400 minutes. In an industry where superstars are worshipped like deities, writing became the star for a change on streaming platforms. "The only way you can stand out in streaming is by creating content that has the social currency to travel, appeals to the largest-paying audience base and can do differentiated storytelling and on a consistent basis," says Prabhakaran, who plans to have a Tamil and Telugu series every month. He has a chief content officer for Tamil and Telugu, respectively, to help accomplish the goal.

The success of Tamil, Telugu and Malayalam films has been instrumental in OTT platforms investing in the creative economies there. And the enthusiasm isn't limited just to India. "Back in 2020, we decided to go big on licence cinema. It paid off really well in forging deep relationships with creators. We curated a good south slate and made our own also," says Monika Shergil, vice president, content - Netflix India. The latter included *Minnal Murali*, which was among the top 10 films in 30 countries, including Argentina, Brazil, Nigeria, Malaysia, and was watched for over 25 million hours, according to Netflix. More than 40 per cent of *Navrasa*'s viewership came from outside India in its first week. The channel also prioritises the customers in the three southern states by dubbing some of its marquee international shows such as *Money Heist* (Spanish), *Stranger Things* and *The Squid Game* (Korean) in Tamil and Telugu. Even as Netflix looks to develop original series in Tamil and Telugu, it reaches out to audiences in these markets by collaborating with Telugu actors Rana Daggubati and Venkatesh, albeit for a Hindi original—*Rana Naidu*—an adaptation of the US series *Ray Donovan*.

The fact that major OTT players are now seeking stories from the south has liberated filmmakers such as Nagesh Kukunoor, co-writer and creative producer of *Modern Love Hyderabad*, the Telugu anthology that dropped on Amazon Prime Video on July 8. "Earlier, your local multiplex in Mumbai would have a show or two of a Malayalam or Telugu film, that too infrequently," says Kukunoor. "Now we can find it streaming a month or so later. For the first time, film industries in the south are getting due recognition. They aren't fringe elements anymore." After years of making Hindi films and series, Kukunoor says he is now "confident" and "glad" to create more in Telugu.

GROWING FIELD

Other filmmakers are following suit. National Award-winning filmmaker Vetrimaaran has developed shows for both ZEE5 and aha, respectively; Pushkar-Gayathri are doing two more with Amazon Prime Video, and Karthik Subbaraj is a showrunner for SonyLIV. "Filmmakers realise that there are stories they are not able to tell in 120-150 minutes," says Prabhakaran. "OTT allows you more nuanced storytelling with characters who have shades of grey." It's a lure for actors too, as they are now shedding their inhibitions about featuring in OTT films and series.

As production budgets expand and licence bids for southern films get more expensive, regional platforms like aha have their work cut out. "We are not going to sign blank cheques like the bigger players," says Thakur. "But competition is welcome. There's a big task of growing the category." aha launched its Tamil interface in April and is eyeing the Malayalam market next. Narrative will be key. "A good story always travels from one part to another," says Prabhakaran. "Southern films in theatres are showing us that." It won't be long before the next pan-India sensation comes down a streaming channel. ■